FORGE

Facilitating Opportunities for Reentry, Growth & Empowerment

A Peer-Led Mentorship Program at Dooly State Prison

FORGE is a 36-week, evidence-based program that trains incarcerated men to become certified peer mentors — reducing dorm conflict, strengthening rehabilitation programming, and building a safer facility for inmates and staff alike.

What FORGE Does

FORGE prepares men to facilitate evidence-based programs, mediate conflicts, lead restorative circles, and model accountability across housing units. Mentors operate within clearly defined boundaries — they do not investigate incidents, impose discipline, or replace staff authority.

The program creates a **self-sustaining pipeline**: certified mentors from each cohort train the next, building permanent infrastructure.

How It Benefits Staff

Fewer conflicts — Mentors de-escalate before incidents occur.
Stronger programming — RISE and Pathfinders get trained facilitators.
More stable dorms — Peer accountability and a culture of restraint.
Clear boundaries — Mentors support staff authority, never undermine it.

The 36-Week Curriculum

108 sessions. 3 per week. 2 hours each. Three phases with formal gate requirements:

Phase 1: Foundation
Weeks 1–12
"Know Yourself" — CBT, emotional regulation, conflict resolution

Phase 2: Development
Weeks 13–24
"Build Others" — Facilitation, MI, simulation training

Phase 3: Practicum
Weeks 25–36
"Lead & Serve" — Supervised mentoring, 60+ hrs, certification

Built on Evidence That Works

Curriculum from **Thinking for a Change** (NIC), **Moral Reconation Therapy**, **GRIP** (California), **Seeking Safety**, **SAMHSA Trauma-Informed Framework**. Structure from **PEP** (Texas), **RSVP** (San Francisco), **Defy Ventures**, **Oregon Mentors Certification Program**.

0.5%	80%	43%	$5 : $1	85%
GRIP recidivism (vs. 41.9% state avg)	Reduction in violent rearrests (RSVP)	Less likely to recidivate (RAND meta-analysis)	Return on investment (RAND Corporation)	Employment within 6 months (Defy)

What Participants Learn

Phase 1: Personal Development

- Identify and interrupt thinking errors (CBT)
- Manage emotions using the escalation curve
- 4-4-4 breathing & 5-4-3-2-1 grounding
- Assertive communication & "I" statements
- FORGE 5-step conflict resolution model
- Accountability spectrum & impact awareness
- Growth mindset & future visioning

Phase 2: Mentor Skills

- Adult learning principles & lesson planning
- Motivational interviewing (OARS framework)
- Simulation-based scenario training
- Restorative justice circles
- Crisis de-escalation protocols
- Co-facilitation practice with peer feedback
- Ethics, boundaries & confidentiality

Phase 3: Field Leadership

- Supervised co-facilitation of Phase 1 sessions
- 1-on-1 mentoring with new participants
- Independent session delivery (observed)
- Community circle facilitation
- Real-time conflict mediation
- Self-care & burnout prevention
- Review board & formal certification

The Self-Sustaining Mentor Pipeline

Cohort 1 — Trained by program founders → **Graduates** — Become certified mentors → **Train Cohort 2** — Co-facilitate Phase 1 for next group → **Cycle Repeats** — Permanent mentor infrastructure

The Stakeholder Model

FORGE treats incarcerated men as **stakeholders** — people with something at stake in the safety and stability of their environment. Dorm culture is shaped daily by peer behavior: how conflicts are handled, whether violence is encouraged or discouraged, and what standards are enforced.

FORGE channels that peer influence into something constructive. Instead of being used to intimidate, it's used to **reduce harm, resolve conflict, and build others up**. Mentors take ownership of their environment — not replacing staff authority, but complementing it with a disciplined peer culture.

A dorm where trained mentors actively build peace is safer for everyone — inmates and staff alike.

Accountability & Standards

- **Zero tolerance** for weapons, violence, intimidation, gang signaling
- **Code of Conduct** governs behavior in class, dorm, everywhere
- **Peer evaluation** at every phase gate — cohort holds you accountable
- **Staff observation** required for advancement
- **Removal** for violations protects program integrity and safety

Standard 2-Hour Session

Check-in 10m	Review 10m	Core Instruction 40 min	Practice / Exercise 30 min	Debrief 20 min	Close 10m

Every session follows the same structure: connection, review, learning, practice, reflection, assignment. Consistency builds discipline.

Program at a Glance

216	12-15	85%	60+	6	790+
Hours 108 sessions over 36 weeks	**Cohort** Small groups for accountability	**Attendance** Required for advancement	**Field Hrs** Supervised mentoring	**Competencies** Scored 1–4 all assessments	**Pages** Guides & workbooks

Mentor Role Boundaries

FORGE mentors operate within clearly defined limits. They **do not**:

- Investigate incidents or impose discipline
- Override staff decisions or claim authority
- Conceal safety concerns — safety referrals are mandatory

The goal is stability, not control. Mentors support institutional safety.

Statistics from source programs. Full program details in the FORGE Program Overview at forgementors.org

Leadership is not assigned. It is forged.

Positive Outreach Development Society, Inc.
Dooly State Prison • Unadilla, Georgia